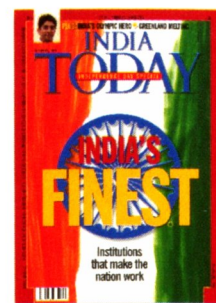


BANDEEP SINGH



"India's Finest",
August 25, 2008

**"These institutions
are India's pride. They
are the finest because
they were started and
are being managed by
people with integrity,
vision and talent."**

DOMINIC AYYANIKKATT,
Karur, Tamil Nadu

Show of Brilliance

Commemorating India's 61st Independence Day by showcasing the history behind the building blocks of Independent India—61 of India's finest institutions ("India's Finest—Institutions That Make the Nation Work", August 25)—is truly commendable. The fact that despite odds like meagre resources, political interference and red-tapism, these institutions managed to stay afloat and churn out luminaries is just amazing. Some of them have excelled, or, are riding along with the world's best in their respective fields.
NALINI VIJAYARAGHAVAN,
Thiruvananthapuram

We should be keen on preserving and protecting the elite institutions that our visionaries have left behind. Institutions, which have outlived their utility,

should be scrapped.
K.S. THAMPI, Chennai

We achieved Independence 61 years ago, but even today we seem to be living in the shadow of the past glory. We need to strive to preserve our hard-earned freedom by keeping alive the memory of those great martyrs, who made tremendous sacrifices first for the attainment of freedom and then for establishing such temples of learning.
VINOD C. DIXIT, Ahmedabad

The Independence Day special issue on India's finest institutions seems to have ignored one of the most important institutions of the country—the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel National Police Academy (NPA) in Hyderabad. Just as the NDA and IMA have contributed admirably to guarding the sovereignty of our country, the NPA, since 1947, has trained officers of the Indian Police Service, who

have been at the vanguard of maintaining the democratic fabric of the nation, and keeping public order. Was the omission an oversight? Or was it just another attempt to downplay the role of the police in nation building?
A.C. VERMA, on e-mail

Instead of shutting down some of the institutes ("Looking for Closure"), the Government needs to re-examine the gap between the objectives with which these were set up and their current manner of functioning to revitalise these famed places of learning.
M.P. SRIRAM, Kochi

You have listed Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA) at Mussoorie as one amongst India's finest. But this view is flawed. LBSNAA has failed in all spheres. It only produces bureaucrats who are focused, but for their self-

ish interests. The civil servants of today have ceased to be both civil in attitude and servants of the people.
S. NIVEDITA, on e-mail

Information Blackout

It is really unfortunate that those seeking information from government agencies are not welcome, not in Bihar at least ("No Right to Information", August 4). The high-handedness of the government agencies, which are falsely implicating people, needs to be dealt with promptly or else this will further tarnish the already-notorious image of the state.
ASHOK KUMAR SRIVASTAVA,
Sitamarhi, Bihar

Flames of Fury

As long as the PDP and the Hurriyat Conference align with Pakistan on religious and moral grounds, giving a half-hearted second place to democratic and secular values of the mainland;